

SI-MI: Social Identity Matters in Mentoring

Session 3: Engaging in Empathic Conversations

Guiding question: How can mentors engage in difficult or vulnerable conversations with empathy while avoiding assumptions and maintaining trust?

Overview: This session focuses on how mentors can approach vulnerable or difficult conversations with empathy, care, and attention. Participants will consider the risks of making assumptions about mentees and will explore strategies that support more thoughtful, responsive communication. The emphasis is on building mentoring relationships that allow for honesty, trust, and mutual learning.

Objectives:

- Recognize the importance of empathy in difficult mentoring conversations.
- Identify personal or structural barriers that can make these conversations harder to initiate or sustain.
- Explore practical approaches that can strengthen communication across differences.

Before the Session: Complete the assigned listening and reading materials, including one of the selected articles. Come prepared to share a few key takeaways and practical ideas from the pre-work.

- **Sign Up:** For [ONE article](#) to read
- **Listen:** [Dare to Lead Podcast - Aiko Bethea on Inclusivity at Work](#) (30:15 - 41:30). [[Transcript](#)]
- **Read your chosen article:**
 - 1) [Martinez-Cola \(2020\)](#). 2) [Benishek et al. \(2004\)](#). 3) [Tanner & Allen \(2007\)](#).
- **Write:** 1-3 takeaways from the readings/podcast and 3-5 concrete actions recommended in the reading you chose
- **Reflect:**
 - What did you notice about the differences between the on-ramps and off-ramps in the role play? How does the identity of both people affect the likelihood of an “off-ramp” during the role-play?
 - Reflect on past vulnerable conversations you may have had as a mentor or mentee. Was the conversation handled with attention and empathy?

What to Expect in the Live Session: The live session will include small-group reflection, discussion of key ideas from the pre-work, and conversation about strategies for engaging in empathic mentoring. Participants should expect opportunities to connect the session content to their own mentoring practice.

Takeaways:

- Empathy in mentoring requires active listening, curiosity, and a willingness to sit with discomfort. Assumptions (especially those shaped by identity or bias) can undermine trust and communication.
- Difficult conversations are not one-time events but part of ongoing relationship-building.
- Practical strategies (i.e., open ended questions, reflection) can strengthen communication across differences.